

EXPERIMENTAL RAIL LINES

Even as official attempts for the introduction of railways were being made, some experimental rail lines, primarily for the carriage of construction material, came up in the middle of the 19th century. This was in response to the huge expenditure usually incurred for road construction and the search for an economical and efficient haulage system. Although these rail systems were only of local importance, the dawn of railways on the Indian horizon can be effectively traced to these precursors.



▲ **The 1845 irrigation project** on the Ganges River included the construction of an aqueduct to cross the Solani River.

It has been suggested that perhaps one of the earliest railway networks in the world, connected end-to-end, came up for the construction of the Taj Mahal in the 17th century. Indian author and railwayman MA Rao says that for easy transportation of marble from Makrana in Rajasthan to Agra in Uttar Pradesh, stone slabs were fixed in the ground, creating a path so that the wheels of bullock carts carrying the marble could easily roll over them. Another similar route was constructed in parallel